CHAPTER 9 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Freedom's Institutions

Denied land and power, freedpeople built something no one could take away: their own churches, schools, and communities. 1865–1877.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

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When a people is given freedom but few resources, what do they build first — and what does that choice reveal?

Churches of Their Own

THE FIRST ACT OF FREEDOM

One of the very first things freedpeople did was leave the white-controlled churches that had preached obedience, and build their own. Independent Black churches — especially the African Methodist Episcopal (AME) church — exploded in membership.

These churches were far more than places of worship. They were the first fully independent Black institutions — centers of community, politics, education, and leadership. Many Black political leaders of Reconstruction were ministers.

The Hunger to Learn

HARPER'S WEEKLY

Across the South, freedpeople of every age crowded into schools. Learning to read had been forbidden under slavery; now it became freedom's first project.

"Zion School for Colored Children, Charleston, South Carolina" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, 1866, public domain (Library of Congress).

Building Black Education

SCHOOLS AND COLLEGES

Freedpeople, the Freedmen's Bureau, and Northern missionary groups built thousands of schools. Grandparents learned to read beside grandchildren. And from this effort rose the first Historically Black Colleges and Universities — Howard, Fisk, Hampton, and others — which would educate generations of Black leaders.

Education was treasured because under slavery it had been a crime to teach an enslaved person to read. To learn was to claim a freedom long denied.

The five military districts, 1867 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Reuniting What Slavery Tore Apart

FAMILY AND COMMUNITY

Freedpeople also used their freedom to rebuild families slavery had shattered — walking hundreds of miles and placing newspaper ads to find spouses, children, and parents who had been sold away. They legalized marriages that slavery had never recognized.

They formed mutual-aid societies, benevolent associations, and businesses. Denied forty acres, they built a social world of their own.

A FREEDMAN, ON LEARNING TO READ

I felt like I was free when I could read my own name.

— FORMERLY ENSLAVED MAN, RECORDED IN A RECONSTRUCTION-ERA ACCOUNT

Read the Evidence Together

YOUR TURN

You'll look at several kinds of evidence about what freedpeople built, and practice corroboration — seeing how different sources point to the same conclusion.